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Reminder that I am just a student too and am only sharing my tips and tricks that have helped me get an A* in the exam:

IGCSE			
Syllabus	Syllabus Title	Result	Percentage Uniform Mark
0500	FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH	A*(a*)	93

General Tips

- Yes the test time is 2 hours and it sounds like a lot but you have 3 long questions so never waste your time and try to complete the short answer questions as quickly as possible !!!
- Read the answer scheme while you're practicing the paper so that you can eventually tell what the mark scheme wants and how you can write your answer.
- **PLEASE HAVE GOOD HANDWRITING THIS IS VERY IMPORTANT!!!** Your messy handwriting can annoy the markers causing them to have a negative impression on you and giving you less marks for your essays.
- The exam generally requires you to have a wide range of vocabulary but if you struggle with this, an hour or so before the exam, memorise a few "big" words and insert them in your essays. This might seem ridiculous but it actually works.

Question 1

- The fastest and easiest question to finish in the entire English Paper
- **DO NOT READ THE WHOLE PASSAGE NEVER DO THAT!!!** You can skim and scan through but do not take too much time doing so.
- At the start of each sub-question they always ask you to re-read a paragraph or two; only read the paragraph then.
- If the sub-question asks you to explain a word, do not write out the answer in a short sentence i.e. "The meaning of this word is _" it not only wastes your time but can also confuse the exam markers so write a word or two.
 - Example: Explain "Reflect Humorously"
 - Answer: Consider amusingly / satirise
- If the text asks you to give reasons or explain then you can be lengthy with your reasons but try to keep it simple. If you really don't know the answer then just put whatever you think is the answer from the paragraphs and word it nicely.
- **Try to use your own words as far as possible.** This doesn't mean to change even the most simplest words. Keep it short and simple.

Question 1(f): Summary

- **ONCE AGAIN DO NOT READ THE WHOLE PASSAGE!!!** The summary will often ask you for one

or two points so only look for those and do not waste time reading it all.

- Underline the points that you find with a pencil. Then number it so that you can have a rough plan of how you will write them out. They don't have to be in order so group the relevant ones.
- Make sure you know at least 5 connecting words and try not to repeat one that you've already used.
 - Furthermore, In addition to, Not only but also, In contrast to, However, Another interesting point to note, etc.
- If you aren't sure whether you are correct with a point, add in another point so if it is not the answer you have an additional point to back it up.
- Try to change every single word in the summary but make sure it makes sense.
- **Do not change the meaning of the sentence.**
- If you cannot find synonyms for a word just leave it and instead change the sentence. Switch between active to passive.

Question 2 (Short Answer Questions)

- Generally same tips as question 1 and once again do not read the whole thing.
- They will give you what line the example is from so only read about two lines up and down it so you can get the context and understand it.

- Again use your own words.

Question 2c

- They will give a short excerpt from the same passage so read through the excerpt and **take only one phrase from the whole excerpt to explain**. I've seen a lot of people try to explain the whole excerpt. No do not do that. All 3 of the marks are from one example.
- Try to explain what the writer wanted the reader to feel so basically the feelings. i.e. thankful, in despair, marvellous.

Question 2d (Writer's Feelings)

- The question will give you 2 paragraphs. Read the whole paragraph and re-read it if you don't understand.
- **Pick 3 phrases that you clearly understand and can explain best.** Don't just pick the first 3 that you see. Lay out all of your choices before picking.
- Write two paragraphs for each paragraph and start the paragraphs by saying the overall meaning and effect the paragraph gives.
- Be straight to the point. As soon as you finish the above sentence go straight to the first phrase and start explaining it.
- For each phrase, **explain (1) the literal definition of**

the phrase and (2) the effect it conveys.

- Strengthen your explanation by adding in the definition of other relevant words in the sentence where your chosen phrase is found.
 - E.g.: The writer further emphasises the feeling of "_" by describing it as "conventional", showing that it is typical.
- Very often one of the phrases will show contrast so try to use that phrase and explain how it shows contrast.
 - E.g. : motionless like a cork in water describes the contrast of him moving despite making any movements.
- Try to read the mark scheme of your practice papers to see what types of answers you can give for the paper.
- Make sure to pick imagery too as expressed in the question. It doesn't have to be anything fancy, something as simple as a simile or a metaphor will work too.
- Writing more points than required is fine but never less so make sure you add in those extra word definitions that I said earlier as some of them can surprisingly count as points.

Question 3

- You will most probably have to read and analyse the

whole text.

- If you followed my tips you should have approximately an hour before the end of this test so do not panic upon seeing the passage.
- You will also have to infer one or two of the points such as the immediate future or what could have happened before the passage.
- **Make sure to personalise your essay whether its a letter, article or etc.** Think like you are the writer of the passage.

1. If it is an informal letter:

- Start off the letter with short and informal greetings. Mention something irrelevant like how you took a visit to the museum last week and bought something then continue with the objective of your informal letter.
- End the letter with something irrelevant too like how you miss the receiver so much.
- For the greetings **do not put sincerely or regards. Something like much love or missing you dearly** makes it sound much nicer.

2. If it is a formal letter:

- Start off with a formal greeting such as dear _ and if you do not know the gender of the person put Sir/Madam or the position of the person such as Secretary.
- Start it off with a referral such as "While I was

walking past my school I saw an ad for your company" or "Recent events have shocked and prompted me to write a short story about how..."

- End it with sincerely or regards.

3. If it is an article:

- **Put a heading and make sure it is shocking and drags attention.** It can even be clickbait just do not make it boring.
- It can be formal or informal based on what website/newspaper or topic you're writing about. If it is for the school newspaper keep it light and informal. If it is for an online streets newspaper it has to be straight to the point and formal.
- For the last time use your own words and add in relevant jokes every now and then if it is informal
- Overall about 5 Paragraphs:
 - 1: Introduction
 - 2,3,4: Points
 - 5: Ending and maybe conclusion

HAVE GOOD HANDWRITING PLEASE I CANNOT STRESS THIS ENOUGH

Check all your work when you are done for spelling or grammar errors and try not to rewrite an entire essay as it takes time.

Finally, **GOOD LUCK TO EVERYONE TAKING THE EXAM I JUST KNOW YOU CAN DO IT.**